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Act No. 143 (H.938). An act relating to establishing the Vermont Homelessness Response Continuum

Subjects: Human services; emergency housing

This act establishes the Vermont Homelessness Response Continuum (Program), which shall be operated by the Office of Economic Opportunity. The purpose of the Program is to establish a continuum of supports and services for households who are experiencing homelessness or who are at risk of experiencing homelessness. The Program consists of varying levels of services, including prevention and diversion services, shelter services, specialized shelter services, and emergency housing services in a hotel or motel setting. The Program also provides permanent supportive housing and case management services to households across the Program, as appropriate. This act describes Program eligibility, time limits, household responsibilities, and reporting requirements. It provides an appeals process for Program applicants and participants through the Human Services Board. It requires the Department for Children and Families to adopt emergency rules for the Program's operation by September 1, 2026, and permanent rules by December 1, 2027. While the Program takes effect on July 1, 2026, this act recognizes that the Office of Economic Opportunity and community partners will not have capacity to fully implement the Program by that date and requires the Office to implement the Program to the fullest extent of its ability in fiscal year 2027, while developing capacity to fully implement the Program in fiscal year 2028. This act articulates fiscal year 2027 Program expenditures.

This act also establishes the Vermont Rental Assistance Bridge Program within the Vermont State Housing Authority to link households who require rental assistance to permanent housing when the household does not have access to relevant U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development rental assistance.

Multiple effective dates, beginning on June 16, 2026